Product documentation canvas: for human and machine readability

Which question does this document answer?

1. What exists? **Reference**
2. What are the rules? **Specifications**
3. What needs to be done? **Tasks**
4. How do I do something? **How-to guides**
5. What changed? **Changelogs**

Document purpose

Who is this for?

Structure

Why this matters?

Plain language

Who owns this?

Accessibility

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What exists? Reference

Define the thing being documented.

Examples of reference docs:

- Component catalogue
- Team structure
- API endpoints
- Design tokens

Questions:

- What exists in this system?
- What belongs here?
- What does not belong here?

Who is this for?

For humans, eg:

- Engineers
- Designers
- Product managers
- QAs
- New joiners

For machines, eg:

- Agents
- Search
- IDE integrations
- Figma plugins

Questions:

- Who needs this information?
- What's their existing knowledge?
- When will they use it?
- What question are they trying to answer?

Structure

Example reference structure:

- Definition
- Props / attributes
- Variants / states
- Accessibility
- Examples
- Related links

Questions:

- Is the structure predictable?
- Can users scan quickly?
- Are headings consistent?
- Does each section have a clear purpose?
- Can machines identify sections easily?

Why this matters?

For humans, eg:

- Faster lookup
- Accuracy
- Verification
- Decision making
- Easier onboarding

For machines, eg:

- Clear definitions
- Accurate retrieval
- Fewer hallucinations
- Reusable knowledge

Questions:

- What friction does this remove?
- What improves if this exists?

Plain language

For humans:

- Short sentences
- Consistent terminology
- Active voice
- Avoid unnecessary words
- Avoid jargon

For machines:

- Reduced ambiguity
- Better summarisation
- Consistent terminology
- Clear definitions

Questions:

- Is language simple?
- Is terminology consistent?
- Are terms defined?
- Could a new joiner understand this?
- English as an additional language?

Who owns this?

For humans, eg:

- Clear accountability
- Up to date documentation
- Easier maintenance

For machines, eg:

- Accurate content
- Reduce outdated info
- Reliable knowledge source

Questions:

- Who owns this document?
- When is it updated?
- How is it updated?
- Is it versioned?
- How are changes reviewed?

Accessibility

For humans:

- Clear structure
- Heading hierarchy
- Lists instead of paragraphs
- Scannable content
- Screen reader friendly

For machines:

- Semantic headings
- Structured lists
- Tables for structured data
- Markdown or structured text
- Predictable hierarchy

Questions:

- Is the heading hierarchy clear?
- Is content scannable?
- Can assistive technology navigate it?
- Is the structure machine readable?
- Is the format machine readable?